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Which Witch Is Strix: The Dual Nature of the Witches in Apuleius' *The Golden Ass*

The witches in Apuleius' *The Golden Ass* are some of the most famous characters to inhabit the Roman literary canon. They're quite humorous, and from them comes many an absurd and humorous scene. *The Golden Ass* itself is a comedic adventure centering around a man-turned-donkey, Lucius, who navigates a fantastical, parodical version of the Greek region of Thessaly, in which he encounters many absurd characters and situations in his pursuit of learning about and bearing witness to the art of magic. I argue here that Apuleius is using a combination of both Greek witch-related concepts and elements of the very Roman strix-paradigm in order to create a type of which that is able to both exist in and parody the fantastical Thessalian setting they inhabit, while also catering to the literary palette of a Roman reader who is most likely familiar with the strix-witch.

To understand his parody, it is first vital to understand that Apuleius is widely known as a comic writer. *The Golden Ass* itself is quite funny, and Lucius and other characters' various witchcraft-related encounters make up some of the most humorous parts. Aristomenes' encounter with the witches Meroe and Panthia is one of the most widely known. It even includes a bit with Aristomenes himself laughing at how— with his bed flipped on top of him— he has been turned into a tortoise (“*Nam ut lacrimae saepiculae de gaudio prodeunt, ita et in illo nimio pavore risum nequivi continere de Aristomene testudo factus.*”) (Apuleius 1.12). Another absurd (and memorable) part of that same encounter is when Meroe and Panthia decide to just squat down

and empty their bladders onto poor Aristomenes (“*His editis abeunt <et una> remoto grabattulo varicus super faciem meam residentes vesicam exonerant, quoad me urinae spurcissimae madore perluerent.*”) (Apuleius 1.13). The humor of these scenes is certainly intentional; One of my personal favorite jokes that Apuleius makes only makes sense in the original Latin. When Socrates is describing Meroe’s feats of transformation to Aristomanes, he describes how “with a single word she changed him into a beaver, a creature that, fearing capture, escapes from the hunters by biting off its own testicles to confuse the hounds with their scent” (Kline I:6-10). In the Latin, Apuleius uses the feminine form of an adjective to describe the beaver— even though *castor* is a masculine noun— since the beaver has feminized itself by chewing off its genitals. As this wouldn’t grammatically make sense without that context, it’s undoubtedly an intentional joke. In any case, it is far from beyond him to use both Greek and Roman tropes to construct a parody of Greco-Roman witches.

As Apuleius is also a Roman writer, it makes sense that the witches seen in *The Golden Ass* bear a striking resemblance to the Roman *strix*-witch. In *The Strix-Witch*, Daniel Ogden constructs the *strix*-paradigm to include a variety of different motifs. Our witches fit many of these motifs; for example, as Ogden explains, “the Romans typically conceptualized witches in general – as we still do – as old women: Horace’s Canidia (‘Grey One’) wears false teeth, whereas her companion Sagana (‘Wise One’) sports a wig” (Ogden 2.1). Apuleius’ witches fit this motif, as our first introduction to Meroe through Socrates’ sad tale is as an old but beautiful woman, an “*anum sed admodum scitulam*” (Apuleius 1.7). The witches in *The Golden Ass* also “appear through the air by night” (Ogden 2.1); all of the witch related action in *The Golden Ass*, whether it's Meroe and Panthia ripping doors off of their hinges around the third watch of the night, “*circa tertiam ferme vigiliam*” (Apuleius 1.11), or Pamphile turning herself into an owl

around the first watch of the night, “circa primam noctis vigilam” (Apuleius 3.21). Even furthermore, the strix is very commonly conceived as “a woman capable of turning herself into a bird, or a woman with avian elements or abilities” (Ogden 2.3), with emphasis as well on her ability to fly through the night doing her wicked deeds (Ogden 2.3). This is, of course, made manifest very directly through Pamphile’s transformation into an owl in book three of the golden ass. With Lucius peeking through the doorway, she anoints herself with oils, sprouts feathers, lets out a few hoots, and flies away into the night as an owl to do her work (Apuleius 3.21). Even moisture extraction, the ability of the strix to “damage a body... by extracting moisture from it” (Ogden 2.9) can be observed as Panthia closes Socrates’ neck wound with a sponge that later appears to suck the life out of him (Apuleius 1.19). From their age, to their transformations, to their nighttime work, the witches in Apuleius’ *The Golden Ass* are clearly tied very intricately with the strix-paradigm.

However, there are some ways in which the witches of Apuleius are noticeably different from other Roman witches. They’re very much set apart from the others; although some of their acts are violent, they don’t come anywhere close to the bloody passion of Erictho, who delights “in the gory and invasive collection of body-parts for her magic” (Ogden 3.4)— and Meroe, the *admodum scitulam*, certainly doesn’t share Erictho’s appearance, whose face is “haggard, vile with neglect, her dreadful countenance of a hellish pallor, freighted with uncombed locks” (Lucan VI.518). While they work with herbs and oils, they don’t use what one would consider ‘cooking’ in their magic, as Ogden describes as a part of the strix-paradigm (Ogden 2.13). In contrast, Apuleius takes ample time to walk his reader through the various animal transformations that Meroe performs. She scorns her former lovers by turning them into beavers, frogs, and sheep (Apuleius 1.9), to name a few. There’s also a large emphasis placed by Apuleius

on physical mediums of magic, as he writes out Pamphile's entire 'getting ready' process as she prepares to turn into an owl, which involves various oils and mixtures (Apuleius 3.21). It all seems to set them apart from the likes of witches such as Erictho and Canidia.

There's something about Meroe, Panthia and Pamphile that feels Greek; they appear to share traits not only with the Roman strix-witches, but Greek witches such as Circe and Medea as well. Medea is no stranger to drugs and ointments; she was "a keen contriver of mixtures of deadly drugs [pharmaka]," (Ogden 78) and some historians say that she used a deadly ointment to kill both Creon and the new wife of Jason (Ogden 81). Medea's use of herbs and drugs is clearly a tradition that continued into the Roman period, as Seneca's Medea describes the titular character as using various deadly flowers, herbs, and toxic plants as she works her dark magic. "Every plant that burgeons with deadly flowers," he writes, "every kind of injurious sap that breeds in twisted roots the sources of harm: all these she handles" (Seneca 715). On the other hand, Circe shares the Apuleian witches' affinity for turning men into animals. Animals surround Circe's home, from the stag that Odysseus and his crew first encounter upon making landfall on her home of Aeaea (Ogden 94), to the wolves and lions she enchanted with "evil drugs [pharmaka]" (Ogden 95), and it quickly becomes very clear as to why. With a wave of her wand, Circe turns Odysseus' men into pigs (Ogden 95), and the implication here is then that the animals that dot the island (in my personal opinion, the stag that stands on its hind legs is still particularly eerie) are all men turned bestial via the magic of Circe. Circe, like Medea, has also dedicated herself to learning all there is to know about herbs and plants—the two are sisters, after all, just as Meroe and Panthia claim to be (Ogden 78). The similarities between the Greek witches Circe and Medea and the Roman witches Meroe, Panthia, and Pamphile are difficult to ignore, and serve to set the Apuleian witches apart from the other Roman witches of Apuleius' time.

The witches in *The Golden Ass* are clearly neither pure strix-witch, nor Greek witch, but something altogether different. Apuleius is writing later than every other author I've touched upon so far; he obviously writes after Homer, but he is predated by the others as well. While *The Golden Ass* was written in the second century CE, Seneca's *Medea* was written around the year 50, and *Pharsalia* in the latter half of the first century CE. Apuleius would've been able to read all of these works, and use them as inspiration for his own writing. His witches are not entirely Roman, but not entirely Greek; they are a combination of the witches that have come before them, and thus serve as an example of how these Greco-Roman works have been received and reinterpreted by the writers who came after them. This blending of traditions allows Apuleius to riff on Greek witches— for it is notable to mention here that his story takes place in Thessaly, and thus it would make sense for Apuleius to employ some Greek tropes— while capitalizing on the popular, strix-focused tropes of his own day and appealing to the Roman reader. Apuleius' Roman parody of Greek witches such as Medea and Circe allows the modern reader to conceptualize the reception of such literary works in the Roman-speaking world.

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